Newsweek, April 18

Every Wi-Fi Cloud Has A Broadband Lining

JOHN NESS OF Newsweek investigates whether two US cities—Portland and Philadelphia—can become entirely wireless cities by next year

NOBODY doubts the benefits of Wi-Fi broadband technology. No longer is a computer user tethered to a wire in order to surf the Web. All you need is to be within range of a Wi-Fi hotspot, and thousands are sprouting up—at airports, parks, hotels, bookstores, coffee shops, college campuses. Business travellers rely on them. Students need them. Everybody with a PC likes them. The only problem is that, though Wi-Fi is spreading fast, access is hardly universal. Most areas of any given locale are not "hot", and even in those that are, being only slightly out of range or behind the wrong building means no more service. The irony of Wi-Fi convenience is that, without ubiquity, dependent users can pretty quickly become frustrated.

The telecoms, while deploying Wi-Fi in ever more places, won't likely be solving the problem soon. Telecoms "target lucrative, high-density markets to make a profit," explains Jim Baller, a Washington telecommunications lawyer. That has led municipalities to begin creating hotspots themselves, as a way to reach lower-density and lower-income areas that a profit-making company would ignore. More than a dozen communities—from downtown Baton Rouge, La., to San Francisco's Marina neighbourhood—now have significant Wi-Fi coverage provided by the government at nominal or no cost. But the real tests of municipal Wi-Fi are in Philadelphia and Portland, Oregon, both of which plan to begin blanketing their entire areas with low-cost Wi-Fi next year. Cities like Chicago and San Francisco are keenly watching those efforts—as are telecoms that have spent millions in for–profit efforts to provide wired broadband infrastructure.

There will inevitably be holes in any Wi-Fi cloud spread across a major city. Signals often don't extend into basements, tunnels or larger buildings—but true believers say the advantages make up for any gaps. They say the poor will get access, cities will be able to run more efficiently and storefront businesses will be able to work online on the cheap. Naysayers, particularly the telecoms, doubt cities or the technology itself is up to the task.

For business travellers, Wi-Fi clouds are being designed to be so user-friendly that anyone can get online as soon as he or she is in town. In theory, once your PC picked up a municipal Wi-Fi signal, all you'd have to do is complete an online registration and pay a small fee via a credit card. Dianah Neff, Philadelphia's chief information officer, says city planners are talking to T-Mobile—a leading Wi-Fi service for travellers—about a roaming agreement that would allow visitors to surf big areas with their T-Mobile accounts.

http://snipurl.com/digit_wifi

Cnet.com, April 7

Do You Really Care For Faster PCs?

C-NET.COM IS THE world's most respected and certainly the most exhaustive technology portal. Senior Editor Molly Wood asks whether faster and faster PCs really make sense

THE future of the desktop is here! The first PCs featuring dual-core processors from Intel have arrived, presenting the first over-clockable chips from Intel since 1998 and offering true multithreaded performance. Just a day after Intel announced its dual-core processors, nVidia unveiled its nForce4 SLI Intel Edition chipset, which lets you run Intel's dual-core Pentium Extreme Edition 840 processor and two nVidia SLI graphics cards. AMD's dual-core chips are probably coming soon, 64-bit versions of Windows are just around the corner, and to deal with all this horsepower, PC cooling systems are bound to get increasingly outlandish—water's just the beginning. But the real question to ask here is: who cares?

Seriously, what are these PCs for? Certainly not the office. As far back as 1999, Larry Ellison was championing a second version of his thin-client network computer, calling the desktop PC a "ridiculous device" and arguing that a complete PC was a complete waste on the desktops of most employees. Many analysts and journalists are advocating the death of the corporate PC, and it's increasingly obvious to all that most of the horsepower of a desktop PC is wasted on employees who primarily use spreadsheets, word processors, custom applications, and e-mail. Dual-core, SLI, water-cooled PCs in cubicles? Er, no.

So, that leaves gamers, the real target market of these machines. I buy that—they're about the only ones (other than graphics pros, of course) who can justify a machine such as the Alienware Area-51 ALX 7500. But how many gamers really need a dual-core SLI PC that, when over-clocked and loaded to the gills, costs around $5,000? For one thing, most current games aren't multithreaded, meaning you can't really even take advantage of the dual-core processors just yet. Obviously, that'll change over time, but won't most hardcore gamers, then, just stick to the DIY approach-adding high-end components, over-clocking, and building elaborate cooling systems themselves?

Moreover, although gaming is a $7.3 billion industry in the United States, it would seem that consoles rack up much bigger sales numbers: 160.7 million units sold in 2004, versus 45 million computer games, according to the Entertainment Software Association. So, who's really going to buy these PCs in the future? And how many $5,000 machines does Alienware have to sell to make the development worth its while?

So, on to the next presumed audience: the digitally savvy home user, who's processing gigabyte after gigabyte of video, audio, and digital photos. Right, sure, we need 4GHz. There's no way the 2.8GHz Dell box I just bought, when properly outfitted with nearly a gig of RAM and strapped to a 160GB external FireWire drive, could possibly be up to the task.

http://snipurl.com/digit_pc